

**What ethical dilemmas arise when balancing equality of
opportunity with meritocracy in educational and employment
settings?**

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Abstract

This essay considers the ethical tension between meritocracy and equality of opportunity within the classroom and the workplace. Meritocracy promotes the idea that success is a function of ability and effort, while equality of opportunity insists on equal opportunity irrespective of background. In practice, these ideals are likely to come into opposition with each other. A high-grade student might have had the luxury of personal tutors and private school, while a lower graded one was brought up in poverty and disadvantage.

Are they equally deserving?

Based on the thoughts of intellectuals such as John Rawls, Amartya Sen, and Michael Sandel, the paper analyses how seemingly equitable systems may result in unequal outcomes. It explores how race, gender, class, and disability intersect to form structural barriers. Through case studies and real-life experience—blind hiring in large business, affirmative action at universities—the paper demonstrates how institutions attempt to balance fairness, performance, and ethics.

The article argues that true fairness isn't about treating everyone the same—it's about recognizing different starting points and building systems that appreciate excellence and inclusion. It argues that there is no perfect solution, but thoughtful policies, inclusive practices, and a reconsideration of what we mean by "merit" can bring more fair and just outcomes to all.

1. Introduction

In most modern, democratic societies, we hear a lot about two big ideas: meritocracy and equality of opportunity. These ideas shape the way we think about success, fairness, and what people "deserve." We want everyone to have an equal chance to succeed. And we want to reward ability and effort. But what if these two ideas clash?

For instance, if we alter admission policies to assist poor students to enter university, does that make the system fairer—or unfairer? If a business provides special assistance to underrepresented groups, is that ethical advancement or favouritism? These are the types of difficult questions at the heart of this paper.

What Do We Understand by Equality of Opportunity?

Equality of opportunity is where all have equal chance to succeed no matter where they come from. On paper, it's a fair game—where family income, gender, or race doesn't stand in the way. In real life, however, it isn't quite that simple.

Some children are raised with access to decent schools, private trainers, and good support systems. Others face poverty, housing instability, or less-resourced schools. So while the rules are nominally the same for everyone, the starting points are not.

What About Meritocracy?

Meritocracy is the notion that people should achieve their success on the merit of talent, effort, and achievement. It is logical: hard work and doers deserve to be rewarded. But the problem is that this system may ignore the underlying advantages that some people already have.

Author Michael Sandel writes about this in his book *The Tyranny of Merit*. According to him, when the winners feel that they earned every single thing that they possess, they may end up being patronizing to the losers—and forgetting how privilege and luck played a role in their success (Sandel, 2020).

Philosopher John Rawls also argues against the notion that natural ability is a just advantage. He stated, "The distribution of natural talents is arbitrary from a moral point of

view" (Rawls, 1971). That is, it's not necessarily so just to reward individuals merely because they happened to be born lucky.

Where the Ethical Tension Lies?

This is where things get tricky. Consider a school implements an affirmative action policy to give preference to students in underrepresented groups. Supporters say that it evens the playing field. Critics say that it dilutes merit by giving special treatment to some groups, even if others did better on tests.

So who's right? That's the ethical question. Attempting to address inequality may, to some, seem to bend meritocracy's rules. But to ignore inequality can guarantee that unjust systems remain in place. It's not about numbers—it's about values, identity, and justice.

Why Education and Work are at the Center of this Paper?

These questions come most obviously in two environments: work and education.

In schools and universities, the question is:

- Who is accepted and why
- Whether the tests are fair
- How to pay for schools more equitably

In the workplace, we face issues including:

- How can companies fairly recruit or promote?
- Are diversity programmes helpful or harmful?
- Should performance always be the first priority?

It is more relevant than ever, in recent years, racial, gender, and social justice movements have pushed schools and companies to rethink. Others, however, feel left out or

resent what they see as "reverse discrimination." The gap between those pushing for change and those worried about losing established standards is growing. This isn't just a policy issue—it's a moral one. We're being asked to redefine success, and who is rewarded.

The Research Question

This article raises a big question:

How are ethical problems arising in trying to balance equality of opportunity with meritocracy, and what are some potential solutions?

What This Paper Will Explore

To examine the question, the paper is organized as follows:

- Theoretical Foundations – We will be learning concepts from philosophy, sociology, and psychology to learn how individuals perceive fairness and success.
- Dilemmas in Education – We will explore real dilemmas like admissions, test scores, and school finance.
- Employment Issues – We will address teacher hiring, pay inequities, and attempts to create diverse workplaces.
- Case Studies – Actual examples from governments, businesses, and universities will be used to illustrate how these dilemmas actually play out.
- Solutions and Policies – Finally, we will present concepts and blueprints that have the potential to make systems both more efficient and fairer.

Finally, last but not least, this essay argues that we cannot just choose either merit or equality. We must redefine what those two words mean now. Success is not merely about results—it's also about effort, grit, and obstacles in the path of individuals. It is only then that one can design systems that are really fair and really inclusive.

2. Theoretical Foundations

At the heart of the equality of opportunity vs. meritocracy debate are some profound questions regarding justice, fairness, and what precisely people deserve. Philosophers, economists, and sociologists have all attempted to answer these questions—each with varying ways of thinking about why systems that appear fair on the surface can still produce unfair outcomes. In this section, we will examine the work of influential thinkers such as John Rawls, Amartya Sen, Michael Sandel, and Michael Young, and how their thinking assists us in comprehending the intricate relationship between fairness, responsibility, and merit.

a. Equality Theories: Rawls, Sen, and Others

John Rawls is a leading voice when it comes to equality thinking. In *A Theory of Justice* (1971), he invites us to think about creating a society from scratch—without knowing if we'd be rich or poor, healthy or ill, privileged or not. He refers to this as the "veil of ignorance." Based on this perspective, he contends that an equitable society would permit inequalities only if they benefit the least well off. Rawls also thought equal legal rights weren't sufficient—equal opportunities for success, so that individuals of equal talent and effort can have an equal chance, irrespective of background.

Amartya Sen takes a step further than Rawls. In *Development as Freedom* (1999), Sen states it's not merely providing people with access to opportunities—it's ensuring that they really have the actual freedom to utilize them. For instance, two students attend the same school, but one must work part-time to support their family and the other has tutors and assistance at home, they're not actually provided with equal opportunities. Sen's response is centered on people's actual capabilities to do and become what is important to them in life.

b. Meritocracy Theories: Sandel, Young, and the Critics

Whereas equality of opportunity is interested in making sure everyone has an equal opportunity, meritocracy is interested in who should succeed according to ability and effort. Michael Young invented the word "meritocracy" in his satirical work *The Rise of the Meritocracy* (1958). He applied it literally as a warning—his fear was that only the "clever" and "hardworking" would dominate, and the rest would be sneered at. Ironically, the word came to be something that people now boast about.

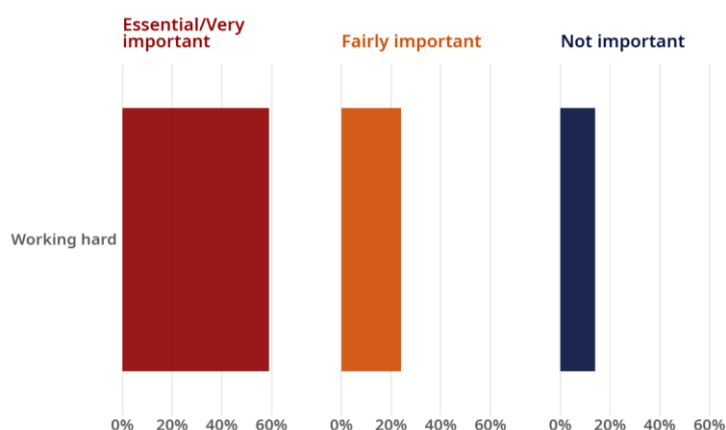
Philosopher Michael Sandel, in his book *The Tyranny of Merit* (2020), argues that this idea of merit is deceptive. He argues that achievement rests too frequently on chance, privilege, and location, and not simply on effort. And if we believe that individuals deserve everything that comes their way, good or bad, then we stand the risk of creating a society in which winners are better than us, and losers are shamefaced. As Sandel writes: "If you've won, you've earned it. If you've lost, it's your fault." But that is to ignore just how loaded the playing field is.

In real life, whatever we call "merit" probably sums up earlier advantages—like good schools, solid homes, and supportive communities—with hard work.

Figure 1: The Role of Hard Work in Achieving Success

A majority of respondents in OECD countries believe that hard work is essential or very important in getting ahead in life. (OECD, 2023)

Share of respondents, OECD 27, 2022

Select a category: 

Note: Results do not total 100% because the survey response "Can't say" has not been included. • Source: OECD (2023), *Hard work, privilege or luck? Exploring people's views of what matters most to get ahead in life*.

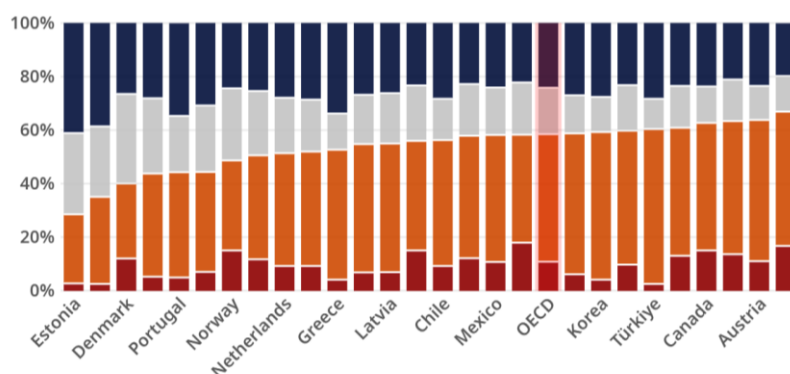
(Source: OECD, 2023. "Hard work, privilege or luck?")

Figure 2: The Limits of Hard Work in Achieving Success

However, across countries, most respondents also agree that hard work alone is not sufficient—other factors such as background, connections, or structural support are also essential. (OECD, 2023)

Share of respondents, 2022

- Other factors are essential or very important but working hard is not
- No factor is seen as essential or very important
- Working hard and at least one other factor are essential or very important
- Working hard is the only essential or very important factor



Source: OECD (2023), *Hard work, privilege or luck? Exploring people's views of what matters most to get ahead in life*.

(Source: OECD, 2023. "Hard work, privilege or luck?")

c. The Conflict between Fairness and Desert

Behind this argument is a hard question: what do people deserve, and why? Meritocracy teaches us that people deserve to advance on the assumption that they deserve it. But authors such as Rawls correct us that even our abilities are not always a question of merit but a question of chance. Do we really deserve to reward someone on the basis of luck in being born with high IQ or a good background?

Meanwhile, attempts to more equally distribute things—such as affirmative action—may have other issues. Others are concerned that such policies may overlook personal effort or result in unfair treatment of others. That's why the concept of moral responsibility is crucial here. Philosopher Elizabeth Anderson contends that fairness is not necessarily equal outcomes—it's treating every individual with dignity, respect, and providing them with a genuine opportunity to fully engage in society.

Sociologist Pierre Bourdieu offers another perspective with his cultural capital theory. He explains how children from wealthier households generally have social and cultural knowledge—such as speaking forcefully or getting through bureaucracies at school—that gives them an intangible edge. When employers and schools reward these traits, they may think they're rewarding talent but are actually rewarding privilege. All of which brings us to an underlying challenge: How do we design systems that will reward talent and effort, but not shortchange the different starting points people start with?

3. Education: A Case Study on a Difficult Dilemma

One of the most egregious—and politicized—locations in which this tension between meritocracy and equality of opportunity occurs is in schools. Schools and colleges are where effort and talent are supposed to count more than where you are from. But in reality, it does

not always work this way. From college admissions to school budgets, the system too often rewards privilege over promise.

Understanding where opportunity and success overlap in education reveals to us the gaps—in policy and equity. The table below highlights some of the most pressing dilemmas in school systems and university admissions.

Table: Ethical Dilemmas in Education – Meritocracy vs. Equality of Opportunity

Area	Meritocracy View	Equality of Opportunity View	Real-World Example	Key Ethical Question
University Admissions	Admit students with the highest grades and test scores.	Account for socioeconomic and racial disparities in education access.	Harvard's affirmative action case; India's reservation system.	Should past disadvantage be considered in defining who is "most deserving"?
Standardized Testing	Objective measure of academic ability.	Tests often reflect income, resources, and prep access.	SAT/ACT performance tied to household income.	Are standardized tests fair when students don't have equal prep resources?
School	Schools succeed through	Equal funding is necessary to	U.S. public school funding	Can we call it a merit-based

Area	Meritocracy View	Equality of Opportunity View	Real-World Example	Key Ethical Question
Funding	competition and results.	provide real access for all.	based on local taxes.	system when starting conditions vary so widely?
Curriculum Rigor	Hold all students to the same academic standards.	Adjust teaching to meet diverse needs and contexts.	Debates around gifted programs vs. inclusive classrooms.	Does differentiated instruction promote equity or dilute excellence?
Private vs. Public Education	Families have the right to seek the best for their children.	Privilege of choice reinforces inequality.	Elite private schools offer opportunities public schools cannot.	How can we ensure fair access when some students have vastly more resources?

a. Access vs. Achievement: Who Gets In and Why?

College admissions are one of the main arenas in which this controversy exists.

Universities try to present themselves as providing benefits to the best students in terms of

academic success. However, what is "merit" usually gets determined by considerations outside of merit itself, like income, availability of tutoring, quality of school, and parental involvement.

Take standardized tests such as the SAT or ACT, for instance. These are intended to be objective measures of capability. And despite this, research has shown that test scores are strongly correlated with the income of a student's family, and not with intelligence or work ethic (Sackett et al., 2008). Students from more affluent families have a greater ability to pay for prep courses, retake the tests, and go to more well-funded schools.

To offset this, affirmative action is employed in some schools—taking into account race, income, or geography in admitting students. The theory is to provide underrepresented groups with a fairer chance and to have more diverse classes. But it's not popular. Critics say it's unfair to admit students who perform lower on achievement tests. But proponents say you can't measure achievement without considering context.

The U.S. Supreme Court ruling in 2023 against race-based admissions by UNC and Harvard reopened this controversy. The court stated these policies violate the doctrine of equal treatment. Critics of the ruling, however, warned that abolishing affirmative action would slash diversity in colleges significantly, especially among Black and Latino students (Liptak, 2023).

This leaves colleges in a dilemma: Do they reward students strictly on grades and test scores? Or do they consider the hurdles students had to jump through in order to obtain those grades and test scores?

b. Private vs. Public Education: The Pipeline of Inequality

This problem doesn't start in college—it starts much earlier. The difference between public and private schools shows how unfair the system is from the beginning.

Private schools provide smaller class sizes, more extracurricular activities, and experienced teachers. But they also come with a high price that most families cannot afford. Public schools, especially in poor communities, are also shortchanged since they don't receive the same local property tax. So children in richer communities get better resources simply because of the community.

That makes it a loop: wealthy families are able to purchase their way into college, and that creates more opportunities for college and more opportunities for employment. That benefit is then passed along. Cultural capital, said sociologist Pierre Bourdieu, refers to intangible advantages such as self-assurance, connections, and knowledge that advantage students and are often confused with talent (Bourdieu, 1986).

For instance, a suburban high school student in a well-to-do neighborhood can take AP classes, serve as a class leader, and attend summer enrichment camps. The same talented student in a low-income school may have none of these. But both are judged to the same level of college readiness. So are we celebrating real achievement—or just the privilege of a better beginning?

To counteract this, some systems use contextual admissions—awarding extra value to students who excel in challenging circumstances. In the UK, for example, universities sometimes use "contextual flags" to flag up students from underperforming schools. This can hopefully balance the playing field, but is also criticized as being hard to apply universally and of causing problems about lowered standards.

c. Ethical Issues: Merit, Privilege, and Equity

These circumstances reveal deeper ethical problems that are not so easily resolved.

1. Is it just to use preferential policies to equalize the playing field?

Policies like quotas or affirmative action are based on compensatory justice—the idea that if people have been unfairly restrained, society is in their debt to enable them to catch up. Supporters argue that these policies benefit people and also enrich classrooms by introducing diverse voices and lived experiences.

But critics contend that assisting some students would disproportionately harm others, particularly those with better grades. This presents a dilemma between:

- Distributive justice (how do we distribute limited seats optimally?)
- and procedural justice (was the selection process used to choose students fair?)

It's a delicate balance, particularly because education is linked to so many individual dreams and expectations. The question is: can we be equitable to both groups and individuals simultaneously?

2. Does meritocracy in school actually reward merit—or privilege?

This might be the biggest question. Colleges and schools say they reward hard work and talent. But what gets rewarded—like good essays, good grades, and leadership roles—too frequently relies on having money, time, and access to resources. Other nations, such as Finland, are another case in point. Their education system provides the same amount of money to each school, minimal standardized testing, and minimal access to private schools. This ensures that all students are receiving the same quality of education, no matter what their background (Sahlberg, 2011). It means that a true meritocracy can only occur if the playing field is leveled from the beginning. On the other hand, countries like America or China—where testing, ranking, and competition are high-stress—generate more stress and more disparity among students. These systems advantage families who can "play the game," and raise value questions regarding what specifically success is measured on.

3. Workplaces: Is Meritocracy Really Fair?

We talk about workplaces being merit-based—that the best guy gets the job, the promotion, the raise. But who is the "best"? And how fair is the system really?

To better understand how ethical tensions between meritocracy and equality of opportunity play out in the workplace, the following table breaks down key areas where these values often collide. Real-world examples help illustrate the complexity of each dilemma.

Table: Ethical Dilemmas in Employment – Meritocracy vs. Equality of Opportunity

Area	Meritocracy View	Equality of Opportunity View	Real-World Example	Key Ethical Question
Hiring Practices	Hire the most "qualified" based on résumé, experience, skills.	Account for structural disadvantages (e.g. race, gender, socioeconomic status).	Blind recruitment vs. diversity quotas (e.g. Deloitte, Norway's board quotas).	Can true merit be measured without accounting for unequal access to experience?
Referrals & Networks	Leveraging trusted networks is efficient and effective.	Reliance on networks excludes those from marginalized backgrounds.	Tech industry's referral-heavy hiring practices (e.g. Google).	Is it fair to value "fit" over diversity and different perspectives?

Area	Meritocracy View	Equality of Opportunity View	Real-World Example	Key Ethical Question
Performance & Promotions	Reward based on performance, leadership, results.	Acknowledge that visibility and leadership roles are unequally distributed.	Women less likely to be promoted despite equal performance (McKinsey 2022).	Should merit include social fluency, or just output and skill?
Parental Leave & Flexibility	Career breaks affect experience, which affects advancement.	Support work-life balance and caregiving roles equally.	Caregivers (often women) miss promotions due to time off.	Is it ethical to penalize life choices that fulfill essential social roles?
Disability & Neurodiversity	Assess based on “ideal” employee traits like communication and teamwork.	Recognize diverse abilities and redefine leadership potential.	Autistic employees excelling in tech roles, but overlooked for management.	Are we unfairly narrowing our definition of professional excellence?

a. Hiring: Blind Spots and Hidden Advantages

On the surface, it should be easy: pick the best person. To make this as equitable as possible, some companies practice blind recruitment—stripping résumés of names and schools so only experience and qualifications are considered. This has minimized bias in some areas. For instance, a UK government report discovered that it made it more likely that women and ethnic minorities would be shortlisted (Government Legal Department UK, 2017).

But blind hiring can't eliminate deeper disparities. Individuals from advantaged groups still are more likely to have higher-quality internships, more refined résumés, and fewer gaps in their careers. And as soon as interviews start, unconscious bias can re-emerge. So even the best-intentioned hiring process may not be as merit-based as we imagine.

Meanwhile, other nations have attempted to correct inequality through diversity quotas, particularly for corporate leadership. Germany and Norway, for example, both have quotas for women in company boards. They argue that this breaks down long-standing barriers. Critics claim it feels unfair to those who do not reap benefits from such regulations, particularly if they perceive themselves as being more "qualified."

There is also the power of networks—who you know can be as important as what you know. In sectors such as finance or technology, recommendations are a significant means of getting a job, which can perpetuate the same sort of people in top positions.

b. Promotions: More Than Hard Work

Once you're in the firm, you'd think your performance would be evident. But promotions usually hinge on factors outside of output—such as how visible you are, the people you know, or how well you “fit in”.

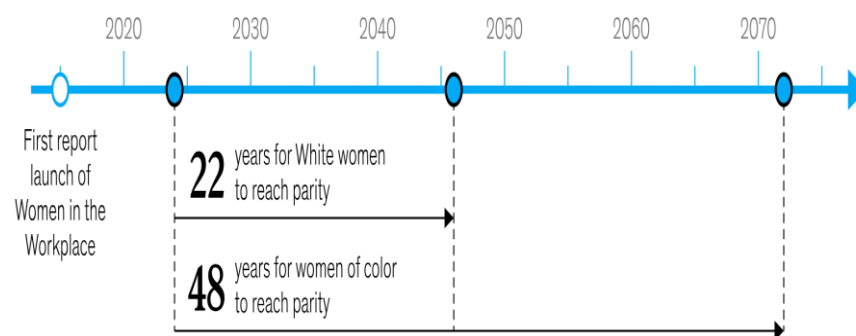
McKinsey research (Field et al., 2024) discovered that even where performance is the same, women and people of color get promoted less. They're less likely to be noticed by senior leaders and frequently excluded from informal networks. Bias also manifests in how behavior is labeled—men are "assertive", while women demonstrating the same level of confidence might be labeled "aggressive".

Figure 3: How Long Until True Gender Equality at Work?

At the current pace, white women are expected to reach leadership parity in about 22 years—but for women of color, it could take nearly half a century. This stark gap shows how deeply race and gender still shape career progress, especially in senior roles. (McKinsey & Company & LeanIn.Org, 2024)

It will take nearly 50 years to achieve gender parity for all women.

Projections of time to reach parity¹



¹Parity is defined as the representation of all women in senior vice president and C-suite roles based on workforce representation trends in the US Census, the current representation of women in entry-level roles, and the assumption that the pipeline and growing population of diverse women will attribute to greater representation of women at senior levels in future. This is 25% of total representation each for White women and women of color, respectively.
Source: Women in the Workplace 2024, McKinsey & Company and LeanIn.Org

(Source: McKinsey & Company & LeanIn.Org, Women in the Workplace 2024)

Individuals who are disabled or neurodivergent may also be overlooked if they don't present as a leader, even if their performance is great. And individuals who need to take time

off for caregiving—usually women—may lose out on critical opportunities, not because of anything they've done wrong.

So the question is: are we rewarding performance, or are we simply favoring those who are most connected and visible?

c. The Bigger Picture: What Does Fairness Really Mean?

All this brings us back to a bigger question: **is merit really objective?**

We keep things like test scores, job experience, or leadership qualities separate. But they're all defined by background—you and your school, your interpersonal skills, your self-assurance. A person might appear to be more smooth just because there were more opportunities for them to rehearse.

That's why there are attempts to make things more equitable—such as quotas or contextual hiring. But they can also fail, generating resentment or making individuals feel they were hired because of their identity, not their talent.

So the actual question is: **Can we reward genuine excellence without overlooking the uneven routes individuals take to get there?**

4. Intersectionality and Structural Barriers

When we talk of school or work being fair, we tend to say something about "everyone having a fair chance" or "the best qualified winning." But life is not a race where we all begin at the same starting line. There are people who run up hills with added weight that some individuals never have to contend with.

That is where intersectionality comes in—a term initially coined by law academic Kimberlé Crenshaw back in 1989. It is one approach to understanding how different pieces of a person's identity—race, gender, class, and disability, for example—are not mutually

exclusive. They cut across and interact with each other, sometimes causing it to become even harder for some people to get access to the same opportunities others take for granted.

Let's see how these converging identities become obstacles in education and the workplace and how this goes against our perception of meritocracy.

a. How Identity Determines Access: Race, Gender, Disability, and Class

Race and Ethnicity

In most of the globe—particularly in the U.S.—students of color are in underfunded and under-resourced schools. This is no accident. It's a product of policies of the past and systemic racism, such as funding formulas that link school budgets to local property taxes. That is to say, if you live in a low-income, predominantly Black or Latino community, your school will have fewer teachers, old textbooks, and less access to arts, sports, or AP courses.

And it doesn't stop in high school. Standardized tests, often thought of as a fair playing field test of merit, are actually an expression of deep disparities. Students of color won't necessarily be able to pay for expensive test preparation or tutoring. And the tests themselves are culturally biased. So the test itself may look fair but actually disadvantages some students from the start.

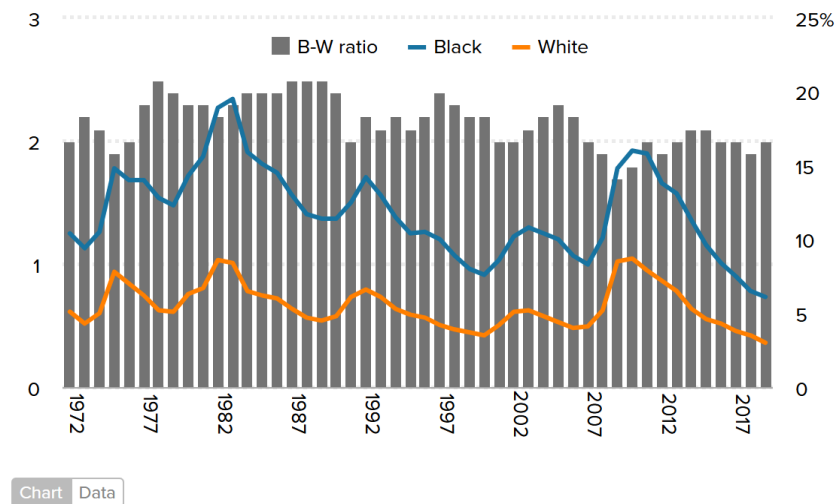
In the labor market, the racial wage disparity is saying the same thing, too. Even when you control for education and experience, Black and Latino workers still earn less than whites (OECD, 2018). So that is not about what people know or what they've learned—it's about what society values and pays for.

Figure 4: A Persistent Inequality in the Job Market

For nearly 50 years, the unemployment rate for Black Americans has been consistently about twice as high as for white Americans—regardless of economic booms or recessions. Even in

2019, after a decade of job growth, Black unemployment was 6.1% compared to 3.0% for white workers. This long-standing gap shows how racial disparities in employment are structural, not just cyclical. (Economic Policy Institute, 2020)

Unemployment rate by race, 1972–2019



Note: Black and white are both non-Hispanic.

Source: 1972–2019 series by race & ethnicity, EPI analysis of monthly CPS microdata, downloaded from EPI SWA Data Library.

Economic Policy Institute

(Source: Economic Policy Institute, 2020)

Gender

Women, and women of color, will be prone to experiencing both sexism and racism. Schoolgirls can be discouraged from becoming career women in the STEM professions (science, technology, engineering, and math), which offer some of the most lucrative careers. This early deviation from certain careers has a lasting effect.

Even at the workplace, things do not get any better. Most women find that even when they do their best, they hit what's referred to as the glass ceiling—a virtual obstacle that bars them from accessing top leadership. Women of color, in particular, are significantly underrepresented in the management and executive levels even when they possess similar qualifications and experience, a McKinsey report established in 2020 (McKinsey, 2020).

And to boot, when women do make it to the top, they tend to have to contend with stereotypes—being labeled "too emotional" or "too aggressive"—charges seldom made against men for the same actions.

Disability

People with disability—neurological, learning, or physical—are occasionally overlooked during discussion of equity but face some of the most formidable barriers.

Students in schools with disabilities do not always get the care they need. There could be an insufficient number of special ed teachers, or the school is not equipped to handle learning differences such as dyslexic or ADHD learning. Neurodiverse students with autism may struggle to thrive in rigid learning settings that limit alternative thinking styles or learning methods.

In the workplace, even with laws such as the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), discrimination and inaccessibility remain monolithic problems. Most businesses continue to believe that an individual with a disability can't perform a job as well—when in fact, with appropriate accommodations, they can do it even better. But stigma typically results in fewer job offers, lower compensation, and fewer opportunities (OECD, 2018).

Class

Your family's income level—your class background—has a tremendous amount to do with what type of education you can receive, and what types of careers you can have. Students who are from low-income families typically attend schools that do not have the resources to properly prepare them for college or careers. They may not be able to afford things like extracurricular activities, tutors, or even a spot in the house to study.

First-generation college students (students whose parents never attended college) usually have another type of unspoken obstacle: cultural expectations. Colleges often take for granted that students are familiar with taking advantage of office hours, internships, or networking opportunities—behaviours middle- and upper-class students may not even know they are engaging in. This unspoken knowledge is one of the things sociologists refer to as cultural capital.

In the workplace, those from lower-class backgrounds would also be at a disadvantage if they don't speak "corporate" or lack professional networks. Without networks, it becomes much harder to get into well-paying sectors like finance, law, or technology.

b. The Big Ethical Question: Same Treatment or Fair Treatment?

This brings us to a straightforward moral question: Do we treat everyone the same, or do we make allowances for differences in where people begin?

The Case for Treating All People Alike

In the traditional meritocratic view, the most fair thing to do is to determine on the basis of performance, achievement, and qualification—regardless of race, gender, class, or disability. It is assumed that the best fairness will be attained by paying no attention to identity as such.

Opponents of such programs like affirmative action or quotas based on diversity claim that these reduced standards or cause resentment. When one feels that they were not hired or awarded a scholarship due to diversity objectives, it generates tension and distrust of the system.

The Case for Honoring Differences

But the reality is, not everybody has had the same opportunity to succeed. If we close our eyes to the barriers that exist, then we're taking a very unequal system to be equal. Philosopher John Rawls thought that true justice is helping the least advantaged—understanding that justice does not necessarily equate to treating everyone the same but providing everyone with the same opportunity.

That's why there are affirmative action programs, special scholarships, or disability adjustments. They're not giving anyone an unfair advantage—they're giving everyone a fair shot so that success depends on ability, not privilege.

c. Real-Life Examples: How Some Institutions Are Trying to Make It More Fair

Diversity Hiring in Technology

Technology companies have been under pressure to diversify in recent years. Companies like Microsoft and Google have committed to adding more women, Black, and Latinx employees—especially in leadership and technical roles.

In 2018, Microsoft began a series of partnerships with groups that help train and hire underrepresented tech professionals (Microsoft, 2018). These efforts are not just symbolic. Research shows that diverse teams perform better—they're more innovative and make better decisions.

Last checked in 2023, Microsoft reported over half (54.8%) of its American employees are ethnic and racial minorities. While women (31.2%) still lag behind, they are part of an ongoing initiative embraced by other behemoths such as Apple and Google.

Scholarships That Change Lives

On the educational side, programs like the Pell Grant in the United States provide economic aid to poor college students, allowing thousands to pay for tuition each year. But aside from money, programs like the Posse Foundation do more. Posse identifies talented high school students from underrepresented populations and places them in small groups—or "posses"—that go to elite colleges as a collective unit. Every student receives a full-tuition scholarship, as well as support and guidance along the way. It's not simply a case of getting them into college—it's getting them to succeed there.

If we want an actually fair society, we have to stop assuming that everyone starts off in the same place. Treating everybody the same might look fair on paper, but in practice it will leave the most disadvantaged further behind. To see intersectionality is to understand that real equality is about listening to people's different experiences, dismantling systemic obstacles, and building policies that allow everyone to move forward—especially those who've had the cards stacked against them their entire lives.

5. The Institutions and Policy Role

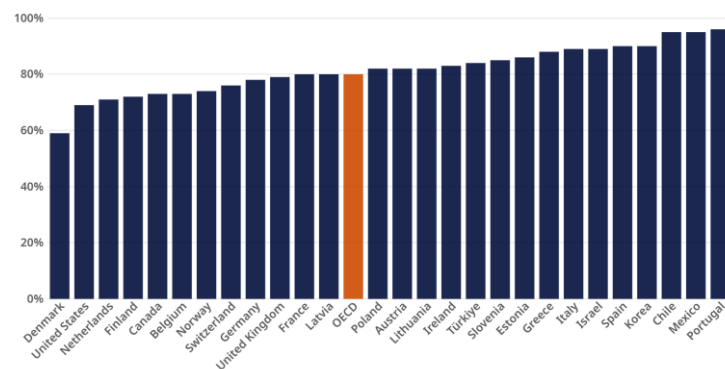
When we refer to balancing equal opportunity and merit, it is not just a matter of individuals working to improve themselves. Institutions—governments, corporations, universities—have a large role to play in setting the rules of the game. Their policies can open doors to more people or, in their zeal, make it even harder for the already disadvantaged.

Figure 5: People Want a Fairer System

Across nearly all OECD countries, most people agree: reducing economic inequality and ensuring equal opportunity should be top priorities. In some countries, support is above 90%. This sends a strong message—fairness isn't just an ideal, it's a shared (OECD, 2023).

Support for reducing economic inequality and ensuring equal opportunity is strong

Share of respondents, OECD 27, 2022



Source: OECD (2023), *Enhancing opportunities by design: Exploring people's views of what should be done to fight inequality*.

(Source: OECD, 2023. Enhancing Opportunities by Design)

Let's see how institutions strive to construct more equitable systems—and where it gets tricky.

a. Government intervention: Rules, Action, and Fairer Access

Governments usually try to make things fair first. By enacting such legislation as affirmative action, job protection, and public education, they try to level the playing field.

Affirmative Action: Useful or Discriminatory?

One of the most controversial policies is affirmative action. The concept is to give a push to individuals from less-represented or historically disadvantaged groups—such as groups on the basis of race, sex, or economics—so they can gain access to employment or education they have been denied for a long time.

Supporters say it's about being accountable for the past and giving people a real chance. Critics say it's unfair or that it's bringing down the standard. A good example is the Harvard case, where the university was sued for allegedly discriminating against Asian Americans in favor of Black and Hispanic students. In 2023, the U.S. Supreme Court ruled

that race-based admissions were unconstitutional (Farrington, 2023). Some considered it a triumph for merit, others a backward step for diversity.

Investing in Fairness: Education and Work Policies

In addition to admissions, governments also try to bring about fairness through more balanced education systems and labor laws. For example, in Finland, all children attend equally funded public schools, and university is free. That is why Finland is often listed as one of the most equal and most successful education systems in the world.

In the workplace, policies like minimum wage, paid family leave, and disabled employee support prevent people from falling behind on the basis of health or money. These policies do depend, however, on political will—and governments or countries are not always in agreement on how far to push it.

b. What Companies and Universities Are Doing

Governments are not the only culprits. Institutions of higher education and big business also decide who is granted access to opportunity and what success looks like.

Diversity and Equity in Recruitment

Over the last decade, more companies have started to focus on diversity hiring—trying to bring in people from different walks of life who haven't traditionally had a seat at the table. Google, Microsoft, and others now track their hiring numbers and have programs to improve representation in roles like tech and leadership.

Even companies practice "blind hiring," where gender, name, and educational background are all hidden during the first phase of hiring. Ironically, the practice was started by conducting orchestra auditions—when ensembles played behind a screen, they hired more

women (Goldin & Rouse, 1997). Deloitte and HSBC now use the same methods to avoid unconscious bias.

But these initiatives raise hard questions:

- Do we disregard race and gender when hiring, or do we use them?
- Is merit incompatible with diversity—or a part of it?

Universities: Weighing Scores vs. Stories

Universities are faced with a difficult dilemma. They want the best performers, but also want to build inclusive, diverse communities. Some use "holistic admissions," looking beyond test scores. They might look at extracurriculars, personal background, or overcoming challenges.

The University of California, for example, dropped SAT/ACT requirements in 2020, stating that the tests gave an edge to wealthier students (UC News, 2020). The supporters viewed this as a move toward fairness. Others were worried that it would be harder to evaluate applicants on a fair basis.

Beyond that, institutions provide these sorts of things like financial aid, bridge programs, and scholarships for underrepresented students. It's not just being fair—it is also about the mission of the university to produce future leaders and empower individuals to move forward in life.

c. Walking the Line: Fair, Fast, and Ethical

The biggest challenge for institutions?

Juggling three big goals at once:

- Efficiency: Saving time and money and getting results.

- Equity: Making sure everyone has an equal chance.
- Ethics: Doing the right thing.

But these objectives are not always compatible. For instance, a company desires a quick, metrics-driven hiring process—it gets the job done but in the process inadvertently weeded out some good candidates who didn't have the same opportunity as a kid. Or, an affirmative action policy brings in more diverse talent, but others fear that it will be perceived as unfair.

Let's look at a couple of real-world dilemmas:

A multinational company operates a leadership program. Acceptance is solely on merit—but the best performers all attended the best schools and shared the same kind of background. Should the company relax its standards to accept those who had more difficult journeys to the top?

A college gives full scholarships to low-income students—but only if they have a 4.0 GPA. That doesn't sound so bad, except what if those students are holding down a part-time job, helping out around the house, or dealing with stresses their peers don't? Ought they to be held to the same expectation?

Institutions are always balancing on a tightrope. They have to balance fairness, effectiveness, and rightness—all at once. And although no policy can ever be perfect, the silver lining is that most are trying their best to try, to evolve, and to learn from what works and what doesn't.

6. Potential Models and Solutions

After all we've learned about meritocracy and equal opportunity, one thing is clear: there's no silver bullet. But that doesn't mean we throw up our hands. Many people—thinkers,

teachers, employers—are trying out new ways to balance fairness and achievement. The idea isn't to blow up the system, but to re-imagine how it works, and who it really works for.

The following are some of the suggestions that can lead us onto a productive track:

a. Re-examining What "Merit" Is

We tend to consider merit as a figure—grades, test results, performance assessments. But perhaps that is too limited a way to view the potential of an individual. It doesn't begin to tell us everything.

Consider this: Two students are both applying to the same school. One had all the advantages—private tutors, study time in quiet, no necessity to work. The other worked part-time, assisted around the house, and still performed well at school. Doesn't that second student's work ethic and determination count for something?

Some already do this. They're employing what's known as "contextual admissions"—essentially, they put students' achievements into context. It's a more human approach, and it gives credit where credit is due. This is picking up pace in the UK and Canada.

b. Inclusive Meritocracy: Making the Race Fairer

The words "inclusive meritocracy" ring shallow—oil and water don't mix, don't they? But the notion is straightforward: we still admire effort and ability, but we ensure that more people get an actual opportunity to demonstrate what they can do.

That means:

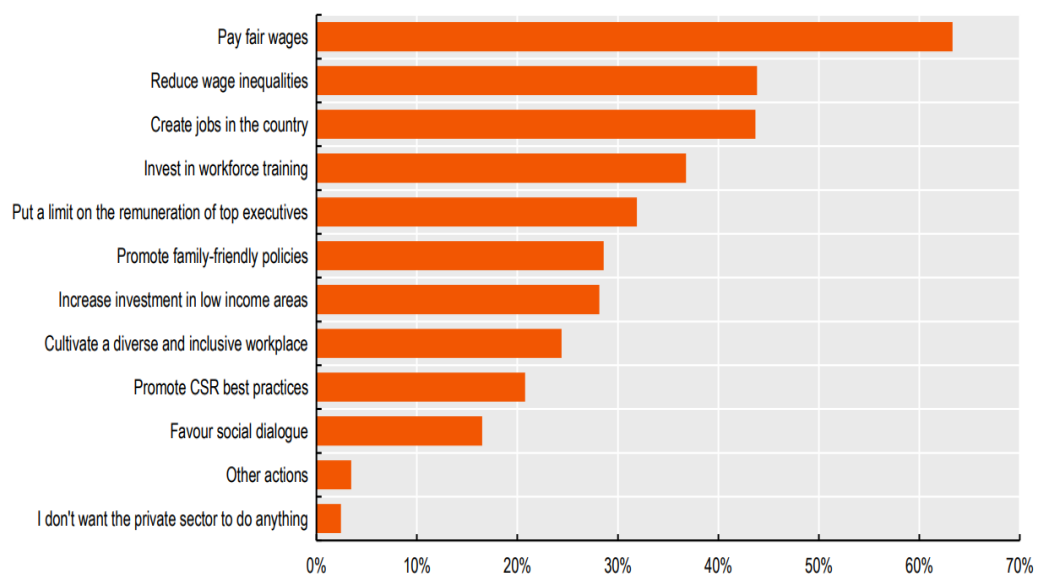
- Mentorship programs for those who were previously excluded
- Internships and training for individuals from less advantaged backgrounds
- Support systems to allow people to stay in school or succeed in the workplace

Look at firms like Google or Accenture. They're developing women's and minority leadership programs—not to lower the bar, but to allow more to clear it. It's not a handout. It's a levelling of the playing field.

Figure 6: What People Expect from Businesses

People aren't just looking to governments for change—they want the private sector to do its part too. Top expectations include paying fair wages, reducing pay gaps, and investing in job creation. Fairness, training, and inclusion clearly matter to today's workforce.

Percentage of respondents supporting the following actions by the private sector to reduce economic inequality and/or foster equal opportunities, OECD 27, 2022



(Source: OECD, 2023. Enhancing Opportunities by Design)

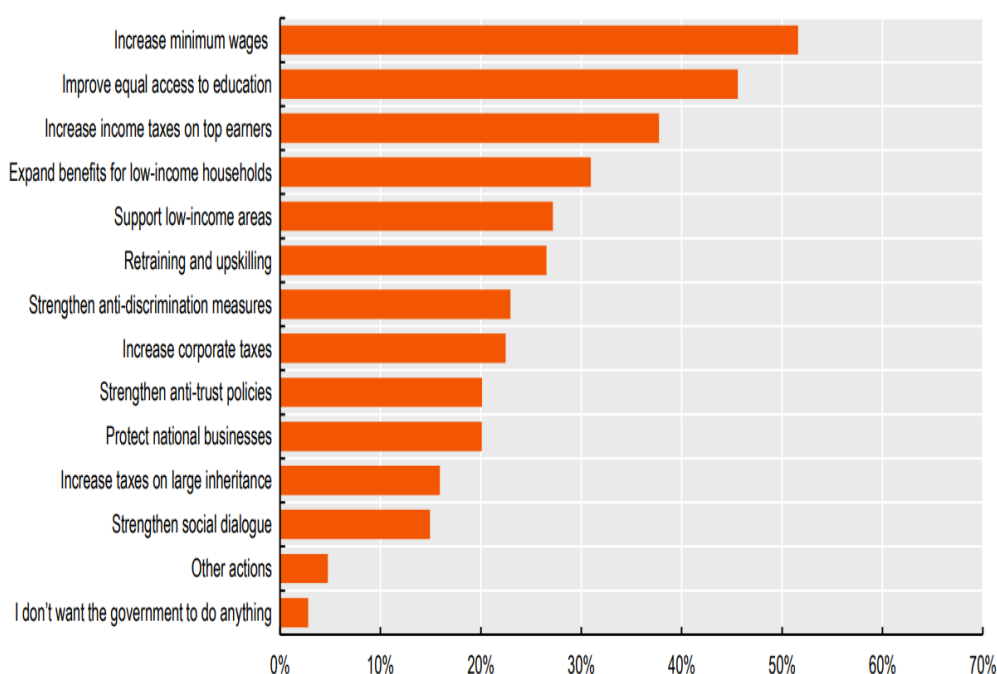
c. Policy Concepts That Benefit All to Have a Level Playing Field

Occasionally things are outside the control of individuals or businesses. That is where good public policy enters.

Figure 7: What People Want from Governments

When it comes to tackling inequality, people across OECD countries want their governments to step up—especially through fairer wages, better education access, and taxing the rich. The strongest support is for raising minimum wages and improving access to education, showing just how linked economic fairness and opportunity really are.

Percentage of respondents supporting the following actions by the government to reduce economic inequality and/or foster equal opportunities, OECD 27, 2022



(Source: OECD, 2023. Enhancing Opportunities by Design)

These are some broad changes that might make opportunity more level:

Early Education for Everyone

Getting a head start makes a big difference. Nations such as Sweden and Finland spend a lot on preschool education—and it's assisted in reducing inequality while improving learning.

Free or Inexpensive College

When it costs an arm and a leg to attend college, it excludes gifted individuals from poor families. Nations such as Germany and some Canadian regions provide free or low-cost higher education—and more individuals have an equal opportunity as a result.

Blind Hiring & Skills-Based Recruitment

Some firms remove names and pictures from resumes to minimize bias. Others don't care so much where you attended school as they do about what you can do. That sort of change unleashes dormant potential.

Long-Term Support

It takes more than just "letting people in." Real equity is letting people in and helping them to thrive once they are in. That may be tutoring, mentorship, mental health services, or even just flexible scheduling.

These aren't shortcuts. They're tools to assist people in succeeding without lowering the standards—just altering the way people get the opportunity to meet them.

7. Conclusion: Towards More Equitable Systems

This entire discussion—of merit, justice, and opportunity—is not abstract. It is played out in life: in the classroom, office, job interviews, and admissions to college. Meritocracy and equal opportunity on the surface seem to be at odds. One talks of the best man or woman winning. The other talks of everyone getting an equal start. But what if the person who seems to be "the best" only became so because they had an advantage?

That's the real ethical question: how do we compensate for talent and work without giving up the level playing field?

Throughout this analysis, we've discussed:

- How schools and tests benefit the advantaged
- How employment systems might have hidden biases.
- How efforts like affirmative action try to equalize the playing field
- And how institutions can contribute to perpetuating inequality or help to decrease it

There is no final answer. But there are signs of improvements.

- More and more individuals are questioning the conventional concept of merit
- Increasingly, more schools and businesses are trying more equal, more equitable approaches
- And more honest arguments are occurring over what exactly fairness is

Of course, there are some tough questions:

Can we repair old imbalances without generating new ones? When does support become an unfair advantage? And can any system ever be perfectly fair? It's not easy. But one thing is for sure: fairness and excellence are not necessarily at odds. With open minds, wise policies, and a willingness to challenge the status quo, we can build systems where more individuals—regardless of where they start out—have a real shot at getting ahead. And maybe that's the most ethical outcome of all.

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